

HOTEL 13

Checked In, Never Checked Out

A C Programming Mini-Project Report

Team Members

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Introduction

Hotel 13: Checked In, Never Checked Out is an interactive text-based murder-mystery program written in the C programming language. A guest checks into a storm-locked countryside rest house and is later found dead in Room 13. With the roads cut off until dawn, only six people remain on the property — three guests and three staff — and one of them is the killer. The player takes on the role of a fellow guest turned amateur detective, interrogating each suspect, examining forensic evidence in the form of a muddy footprint, and finally naming the killer before the story reaches one of three possible endings.

Project Summary

The program is organized into six sequential scenes, each handled by its own function:

- Scene 1 — The Body: introduces the setting, the storm, and the discovery of the victim in Room 13, along with the size-11 footprint clue.
- Scene 2 — Interrogate the Guests: the player questions each of the three guests, choosing to press hard or ask gently, which affects that suspect's suspicion score.
- Scene 3 — Interrogate the Staff: the same interrogation process is repeated for the three staff members.
- Scene 4 — The Footprint: the player recalls the footprint size from Scene 1 and matches it against staff boot records, narrowing down the suspect list.
- Scene 5 — Suspicion Summary: the program prints the final suspicion score for all six suspects.
- Scene 6 — The Accusation: the player types the name of the person they believe is guilty. Depending on the accused suspect and the strength of the evidence gathered, the program prints one of three endings.

The story concludes with three possible outcomes: Case Closed (the correct suspect is accused with strong evidence), Right Suspect, Weak Case (the correct suspect is accused but the suspicion score is too low), or The Killer Walks Free (the wrong suspect is accused).

C Concepts Used

- Strings and Arrays — suspect names, roles, motives, and alibis are stored as parallel string arrays; suspicion scores are stored in an integer array.
- Functions — each scene is written as its own function, and helper functions (pause_for_effect, readLine) are reused across the program.
- Input/Output Functions — printf for displaying story text, and scanf / fgets for reading the player's choices and their final accusation.
- If-Else statements — used to score interrogation choices, match the footprint to a suspect, and determine which of the three endings is shown.
- Constants (#define) — NUM_SUSPECTS, NAME_LEN, and TEXT_LEN are defined once and reused throughout, instead of repeating raw numbers.

Sample Output

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      MURDER AT HOTEL 13
=====
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SCENE 1- THE BODY IN ROOM 13

The storm knocked out the phone lines an hour ago. Now the caretaker is pounding on your door: a guest has been found dead in Room 13. No roads in or out until the storm breaks at dawn.

Only six people were on the property tonight--three guests, three staff. One of them did this.

Kneeling by the back door, you find a single muddy footprint, clearly left by a hotel-issued boot, size 11.

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SCENE 2 - INTERROGATE THE GUESTS

-- Rosalind Vance (Guest) --

Motive: An inheritance dispute over a business she shared with the victim

Alibi: Says she was reading alone in the lounge all night

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
- 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely

> 1

They get flustered under pressure and their story wavers slightly.

-- Thomas Ferris (Guest) --

Motive: The victim owed him a large, unpaid gambling debt

Alibi: Claims he was on a long phone call in his room

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
- 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely

> 1

They get flustered under pressure and their story wavers slightly.

-- Meera Kapoor (Guest) --

Motive: She was secretly investigating the victim for a scandal

Alibi: Says she was writing notes in the dining hall

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
- 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
 - 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely
- > 2

They relax and speak openly, but offer nothing new.

SCENE 3 - INTERROGATE THE STAFF

-- Gideon Marsh (Staff) --

Motive: The victim threatened to have him fired after 20 years of service

Alibi: Claims he was locking up the front gate before the storm hit

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
 - 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely
- > 2

They relax and speak openly, but offer nothing new.

-- Priya Nandan (Staff) --

Motive: The victim humiliated her in front of everyone at dinner

Alibi: Says she was cleaning the kitchen after dinner

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
- 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely

Alibi: Says she was cleaning the kitchen after dinner

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
 - 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely
- > 2

They relax and speak openly, but offer nothing new.

-- Callum Reed (Staff) --

Motive: The victim caught him stealing from the hotel safe

Alibi: Claims he was patrolling the east wing on his usual rounds

How do you question them?

- 1) Press hard on the details of their alibi
 - 2) Ask gently and let them talk freely
- > 1

They get flustered under pressure and their story wavers slightly.

SCENE 4 - THE FOOTPRINT

You compare the size-11 footprint against the staff boot records:

Gideon Marsh (Caretaker):	size 9
Priya Nandan (Cook):	size 7
Callum Reed (Watchman):	size 11

Enter the footprint size to check for a match: 11

The print matches Callum Reed's boots.
But he claimed to be in the EAST wing.
The footprint was found at the WEST wing back door.
His alibi does not hold up.

SCENE 5 - SUSPICION SUMMARY

Rosalind Vance	Suspicion: 2
Thomas Ferris	Suspicion: 2
Meera Kapoor	Suspicion: 1
Gideon Marsh	Suspicion: 1
Priya Nandan	Suspicion: 1
Callum Reed	Suspicion: 7

SCENE 6 - THE ACCUSATION

Suspects:
Rosalind Vance
Thomas Ferris
Meera Kapoor
Gideon Marsh
Priya Nandan
Callum Reed

Who do you accuse? Callum Reed

You lay out the footprint, the contradicted alibi,
and the motive. Callum Reed has no answer.

ENDING: CASE CLOSED

YOU WIN! You correctly identified Callum Reed as the killer.

Thank you for playing MURDER AT HOTEL 13.

♣ ■